

LECTURE 2

Collaboration, Interpersonal Communication, and Business Etiquette

Interpersonal Skills



EMBA 501

Business Communication

Ayesha Siddika Arshi

Lecturer

Dept. of Finance & Banking

Learning Objectives:

1. List the advantages and disadvantages of working in **teams**, describe the **characteristics of effective teams**.
2. Offer **guidelines for collaborative communication** and explain how to give **constructive feedback**.
3. List the key steps needed to ensure productive team meetings.
4. Identify **three major modes of listening**, describe the **listening process**, and explain the **problem of selective listening**.
5. Explain the **importance of nonverbal communication** and identify six major **categories of nonverbal expression**.
6. Explain the importance of **business etiquette**, and identify four key areas in which good etiquette is essential.

LO 2.1

Communicating Effectively in Teams.



COLLABORATION

What is a Team?

A team is a unit of **two or more people** who share a **mission and the responsibility** for working to **achieve their goal**.

You will participate in teams throughout your career, so developing the skills to communicate successfully in team settings will give you an important advantage.

Advantages of Teams:

Teams are often at the **core of participative management**, the effort to **involve** employees in the company's **decision-making process**.

The advantages of teams include the following:

1. Increased **information and knowledge**: By aggregating the resources of several individuals, teams bring more information to the decision process.
2. Increased **diversity of views**: Team members can bring a variety of viewpoints to the decision process if these diverse views are guided by a shared goal.
3. Increased **acceptance of solutions**: Those who participate in decision making are more likely to support the decision and encourage others to accept it.
4. Increased **performance levels**: Effective teams can be better than top-performing individuals at solving complex problems.

Disadvantages of Teams:

The disadvantages of teams include the following:

1. Like other social structures, business teams can generate **tremendous pressures to conform**. Grouphink occurs when peer pressures cause individual team members to withhold contrary or unpopular opinions and to go along with decisions, they don't really believe in. The result can be decisions that are worse than the choices the team members might have made individually.
2. Some team members may have a hidden agenda—private, counterproductive motives that **affect the group's interaction**.
3. Still another drawback to teamwork is the high cost of coordinating group activities. Aligning schedules, arranging meetings, and coordinating a project can **eat up a lot of time and money**.

Characteristics of Effective Teams:

- **Effective teams share a number of traits, including:**
 - i. Clear objective
 - ii. Shared sense of purpose
 - iii. Full engagement from all team members
 - iv. Consensus decision making
 - v. Creativity and technical skills
 - vi. Communication

Teams that lack one or more of these attributes can get bogged down in conflict or waste time and resources pursuing unclear goals.

LO 2.2

Collaborating on Communication Efforts.



Guidelines for Collaborative Writing :

- In any collaborative effort, recognize that **team members coming from different backgrounds may have different work habits or priorities.**
- To collaborate effectively, everyone involved must be **flexible, open to other opinions,** and **focused on team objectives** rather than on individual priorities.
- The following guidelines will help you work together more successfully:

1

Select Collaborators Carefully

5

Select Collaborators Carefully

2

Agree on Goals Before You Start

6

Avoid Writing as a Group

3

Give the Team Some Time to Bond

7

Use Compatible Technologies

4

Clarify Individual Responsibilities

8

Seek Feedback from the Team Often

Guidelines for Collaborative Writing :

The following guidelines will help you work together more successfully:

1. **Select collaborators carefully:** Choose a combination of people who have the experience, information, and talent needed for each project.
2. **Agree on project goals before you start:** Starting without a clear idea of what you hope to accomplish will lead to frustration and wasted time.
3. **Give your team time to bond before diving in:** Make sure people can get to know each other before being asked to collaborate.
4. **Clarify individual responsibilities:** This is essential because team members will be depending on each other.
5. **Establish clear processes:** Make sure everyone knows how the work will be managed from start to finish.
6. **Avoid writing as a group:** Group writing can be a slow, painful process, so assign the actual writing to one person or divide larger projects among multiple writers.
7. **Make sure tools and techniques are ready and compatible across the team:** Minor details such as different versions of software can delay projects.
8. **Check to see how things are going along the way:** Don't assume that everything is working, just because you don't hear anything negative.

Guidelines for Collaborative Writing :

- **Collaborative communication often involves giving and receiving feedback about writing efforts.**
- **Constructive feedback**, sometimes called constructive criticism, focuses on the process and outcomes of communication, not on the people involved.
- In contrast, **destructive feedback** delivers criticism with no effort to stimulate improvement.
- When you're giving feedback, **avoid personal attacks and give the person clear guidelines for improvement.**
- When you receive constructive feedback, resist the urge to defend your work or deny the validity of the feedback. Instead, **use the feedback to learn and to improve the quality of your work.**

LO 2.3

Making Your Meetings More Productive.



Preparing for Meetings:

Successful meetings start with thoughtful preparation. After you have confirmed that a meeting is necessary, proceed with the **following planning tasks:**

- **Clarify your purpose for the meeting:** **Informational meetings** allow participants to share information and perhaps coordinate action. **Decision-making meetings** involve persuasion, analysis, and problem solving.
- **Select participants for the meeting:** The rule here is simple: Invite everyone who really needs to be involved, and don't invite anyone who doesn't need to be there.
- **Choose the venue and the time:** Online meetings are often the best way to connect people in multiple locations or to reach large audiences. For onsite meetings, review the facility and the seating arrangements. If you have control over the timing, morning meetings are often more productive because people are generally more alert and not yet engaged with the work of the day.
- **Set and share the agenda of the meeting:** People who will be presenting information need to know what is expected of them, non-presenters need to know what will be presented so they can prepare questions, and everyone needs to know how long the meeting will last. In addition, the agenda is an important tool for guiding the progress of the meeting.

Conducting and Contributing to Efficient Meetings:

Everyone in a meeting plays a role in keeping the meeting productive and making it successful. If you're the leader of a meeting, however, you have an extra degree of responsibility and accountability. To ensure productive meetings, be sure to do the following:

1. **Keep the meeting on track.** Good leaders need to guide, mediate, probe, stimulate, summarize, and redirect discussions that have gotten off track.
2. **Follow agreed-upon rules.** The larger the meeting, the more formal you will need to be.
3. **Encourage participation.** Some participants are too quiet and others are too talkative. The best meetings are those in which everyone participates, so a leader must not let one or two people dominate the meeting while others remain silent.
4. **Participate actively.** Try to contribute to the subject of the meeting and the smooth interaction of the participants. Listen and observe. Speak up if you have something useful to say, but don't monopolize the discussion.
5. **Use mobile devices respectfully.** Tweeting key points from a speech or jotting down notes on your tablet can be productive and respectful. Checking Facebook and working on unrelated tasks are not.
6. **Close effectively.** At the end of the meeting, verify that the objectives have been met; if not, schedule follow-up work. Summarize the decisions reached and make sure everyone understands and agrees on the outcome.

Putting Meeting Results to Productive Use:

- In most cases, the value of a meeting doesn't end when the meeting ends.
- For example, problems or opportunities brought up during a meeting need to be addressed, any action items assigned during the meeting need to be acted on, and key decisions and announcements should be distributed to participants and those who were unable to attend.
- The conventional method of recording meetings is through written **meeting minutes**, a **summary of the important information presented and the decisions made**. One person is usually assigned to keep notes as the meeting progresses and then to share them afterward.
- The **specific format of the minutes is less important** than making sure you record all the key information, particularly regarding responsibilities that were assigned during the meeting.
- Any handouts, electronic slides, or supporting documents can be attached to the minutes when they are distributed.
- Depending on the meeting technologies at your disposal, you may have software specifically designed to record, distribute, and store meeting minutes.

LO 2.4

Improving Listening & Non-Verbal Communications Skills.



Improving Your Listening Skills:

- Effective listening:
 - i. **strengthens organizational relationships,**
 - ii. **alerts the organization to opportunities for innovation,**
 - iii. **allows the organization to manage growing diversity**both in the **workforce and among the customers it serves.**
- Conversely, poor listening skills can cost companies millions of dollars each year as a result of lost opportunities, legal mistakes, and other errors.
- Various types of listening includes:
 - A. Content Listening**
 - B. Critical Listening**
 - C. Empathic Listening**
 - D. Active Listening**

Improving Your Listening Skills:

1. The goal of **content listening** is to understand and retain the speaker's message. You may ask questions, but don't argue or judge. Just **focus on the information**.
2. The goal of **critical listening** is to understand and evaluate the meaning of the speaker's message on several levels, such as the logic of the argument, the strength of the evidence, the validity of the conclusions, the implications of the message for you and your organization, the speaker's intentions and motives, and the omission of any relevant points. **Be on the lookout for speaker bias, and separate opinions from facts.**
3. The goal of **empathic listening** is to understand the speaker's feelings, needs, and wants so that you can appreciate his or her point of view. By listening in an empathic way, you help the individual vent the emotions that prevent a clear-headed approach to the subject. Avoid the temptation to give advice. **Try not to judge the individual's feelings. Just let the other person talk.**
4. Effective listeners try to engage in **active listening**. They make a conscious effort to **turn off their own filters and biases to truly hear and understand what the other party is saying**. They ask questions, summarize the speaker's message to verify key points, and encourage the speaker through positive body language and supportive feedback.

Overcoming Barriers to Effective Listening:

Good listeners look for ways to overcome potential barriers throughout the listening process.

1. **Selective listening** is one of the most common barriers. If your mind wanders, you often stay tuned out until you hear a word or phrase that gets your attention once more. But by that time, you're unable to recall what the speaker actually said; instead, you remember what you think the speaker probably said.
2. **Selective perception** leads listeners to mold messages to fit their own conceptual frameworks. Listeners sometimes make up their minds before fully hearing the speaker's message, or they engage in defensive listening—protecting their egos by tuning out anything that doesn't confirm their beliefs or their view of themselves.
3. Even when your intentions are good, you can still misinterpret incoming messages if you and the speaker **don't share enough language or experience**. When listening to a speaker whose native language or life experience is different from yours, try to paraphrase that person's ideas. Give the speaker a chance to confirm what you think you heard or to correct any misinterpretation.

Nonverbal Signals in Communication:

- **Nonverbal signals** play a vital role in communication because they can **strengthen a verbal message** (when the nonverbal signals match the spoken words), weaken a verbal message (when nonverbal signals don't match the words), or replace words entirely.
- *For example, you might tell a client that a project is proceeding on time and within budget, but your forced smile and nervous glances send an entirely different message.*
- **Six types of signals are particularly important:**
 - i. Facial Expressions.
 - ii. Gesture and postures.
 - iii. Vocal characteristics.
 - iv. Personal appearance.
 - v. Touch.
 - vi. Time and space.

Nonverbal Signals in Communication:

Six types of signals are particularly important:

1. **Facial Expressions.** Your face is the primary site for expressing your emotions; it reveals both the type and the intensity of your feelings.
2. **Gesture and postures.** Many gestures (e.g., a wave of the hand) have a specific and intentional meaning.
3. **Vocal characteristics.** Your voice also carries intentional and unintentional messages. Your tone, volume, accent, and speaking pace say a lot about who you are, your relationship to the audience, and the emotions behind your words.
4. **Personal appearance.** To make a good impression, adopt the style of the people you want to impress.
5. **Touch.** Touch can convey warmth, comfort, and reassurance. However, touch is so powerful that cultural customs govern it.
6. **Time and space.** Time and space can be used to assert authority, imply intimacy, and send other nonverbal messages.

When you listen to others, pay attention to **nonverbal cues**. **Be observant**, but **don't think you can "read someone like a book."** Think carefully about the nonverbal signals you send to those around you. Don't let careless choices or disrespectful habits undermine you on the job.

LO 2.5

Developing Your Business Etiquette.



Business Etiquette in the Workplace:

- Workplace etiquette includes a variety of behaviors, habits, and aspects of nonverbal communication.
- Your **personal appearance** often has considerable impact on your career success. Pay attention to the style of dress where you work and adjust your style to match.
- In addition to your clothing, **grooming** affects the impression you give others in the workplace. Pay close attention to cleanliness and avoid using products with powerful scents, such as perfumed soaps and colognes.
- IM and other text-based tools have taken over many exchanges that used to take place over the phone, but **phone skills** are still essential. Because phone calls lack the visual richness of face-to-face conversations, you have to rely on your attitude and tone of voice to convey confidence and professionalism.

Business Etiquette Online:

Here are **some guidelines** to follow whenever you are representing your company while using **electronic media**:

- **Avoid personal attacks** on others. Don't lose your temper; stay cool.
- **Stay focused** on the original topic. If you want to change the subject, start a new message or thread.
- **Don't present opinions as facts.** Let people know when you're presenting your beliefs or opinions.
- **Support facts with evidence.** Seek out credible sources of information. Cite the sources of facts, data, statistics, etc.
- **Follow the basic rules for spelling, punctuation, and capitalization.** If you send messages that are riddled with spelling or grammar errors, you'll look like an amateur.
- **Use anti-virus software** and keep it up to date. Sending or posting infected files puts others at risk.
- **Ask** if this is "a good time" for an Instant Message chat before you start. Don't assume that the person wants to chat when you do.
- **Watch your language and control your emotions.** An emotional outburst on the internet or social media can take on a life of its own.
- **Do not waste other people's time** with sloppy, confusing, or incomplete messages.

Business Etiquette Using Mobile Devices:

- **Your mobile device habits say a lot about how much respect you have for the people around you.**
- Selecting obnoxious ring tones, talking loudly in public places, invading someone's privacy by using your phone's camera in inappropriate places, texting while someone is talking to you, allowing incoming calls to interrupt meetings or discussions—these are all disrespectful choices that will reflect negatively on you.
- **Don't assume that your habits will be universally acceptable.**
- Expectations and policies regarding mobile device use vary widely from company to company. Make sure you understand the situation in your workplace.

THE END.

